

ART & CULTURE



RELIGION AND PHILOSOPHY

MODULE - 7

**JAINISM - TEACHINGS
AND PHILOSOPHY**

JAINISM

TABLE OF CONTENTS



1. ORIGIN/HISTORY OF JAINISM

2. TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHY



3. JAIN SCRIPTURES

4. JAIN SYMBOLS

5. VARIOUS SECTS IN JAINISM

6. IMPORTANT RELIGIOUS PRACTICES

Non-Violence – Ahimsa

Many-sided reality – Anekantavada

Triratnas – Knowledge, Faith & Conduct

Dravya

Tattvas of Jainism

Views on Soul & Karma

Views on God & Salvation

Digambaras & Svetambaras

JAINISM

AN INTRODUCTION



- 1 Jainism along with Hinduism and Buddhism is among the oldest of all existing religions.
- 2 This faith is said to have been propounded by Mahavira in the 6th century BCE.
- 3 At present there are 4.5 to 5 million Jains in the world and the followers are mostly concentrated in India.
- 4 However, within India, the followers are spread in almost all the states and union territories.
- 5 As a community, despite the small numbers (less than 0.5% of the Indian population), it enjoys good prosperity and literacy.
- 6 Today, it is considered to be a separate religion distinct from Hinduism and has been accorded a minority community status in India.



CAUSES FOR THE RISE OF JAINISM AND BUDDHISM

1 Primary cause was **religious unrest** in India in the 6th century B.C.

2 Complex rituals and sacrifices were not acceptable to common people.

3 Certain beliefs and mantras confused the people.

4 Teachings of Upanishads were highly philosophical in nature.

5 **Rigid caste system** where the higher classes enjoyed all the privileges.

6 **Kshatriyas** resented domination of priestly class. Both Buddha and Mahavira belonged to Kshatriya origin.

9 Ritual killing of animal for sacrifices was not favoured in agro economy

8 Economy changed from pastoral to agro and trade.

- 7
- **Growth of trade** led to improvement in the economic conditions of the **Vaisyas**.
 - As a result, they wanted to **enhance their social status** but the orthodox Varna system did not allow this.
 - Therefore, this merchant class supported Buddhism and Jainism.

JAINISM

A BRIEF HISTORY



1 The philosophy of Jainism is based on the teachings of **24 Tirthankaras**.

2 **Rishabhath** was the first Tirthankara and **Mahavira** was the 24th and the last Tirthankara.

3 As a philosophy, Jainism is as old as Vedic Hinduism with Rishabhanath, being referred to in the Vedas.

4 Rishabhath (also known as Adinath) is also considered as an incarnation of Lord Vishnu in the Puranas.

5 Jainism flourished as a separate religious philosophy only after the advent of Mahavira, the last Tirthankara.

JAINISM

A BRIEF HISTORY



6 The excessive ritualism, animal sacrifices, etc. which were opposed by the Jain teachings along with its emphasis on Ahimsa, compassion, morality, ethics, and other precepts, enabled it to spread in the country.

7 However, with the regeneration of Hinduism in the 8th century CE, Jainism was pushed to the social fringes and also literally so to the states of Gujarat, Rajasthan, and southern India, where the community still has a greater presence even today.

JAINISM

THE LIFE AND TIMES OF MAHAVIRA

1

Vardhaman was the son of king **Siddhartha** (the chief of Jnatrika clan), and queen **Trishala**.

2

He was born in 599 BC in **Kundagrama** (Vaishali in present day Bihar).

3

At an age of 30, he renounced his family and kingdom including all worldly possessions, even his clothes, and set out in search of the truth.

4

He wandered for many years as an ascetic, performing penance and meditation



7

After attainment of Kaivalya (enlightenment – true knowledge) he preached for several years.

6

He was also referred as **Nigrantha** (or Nigantha), one who is free from attachments and vices.

5

Later, he eventually found true knowledge (**Kaivalya**) and thus became **Jina** (or the conquer), or Mahavira (the great one).

8

At the age of 72, he is said to have attained Nirvana at Pavapuri (Bihar).

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHIES OF JAINISM

As such, one must practice Ahimsa or non-violence/non-injury particularly to human beings, animals, and even to insects and plants.

This would include even the apparently non-living things such as water, stones, etc.

As per Jain philosophy, the whole world is **animated (has life)**.

Intentional harm and absence of compassion makes the act more violent.

The life and conduct of Jains is often shaped by non-violence **making vegetarianism essential to their conduct**.



The strict followers of Jainism travel only on foot and do not travel by vehicles as it could trample insects.

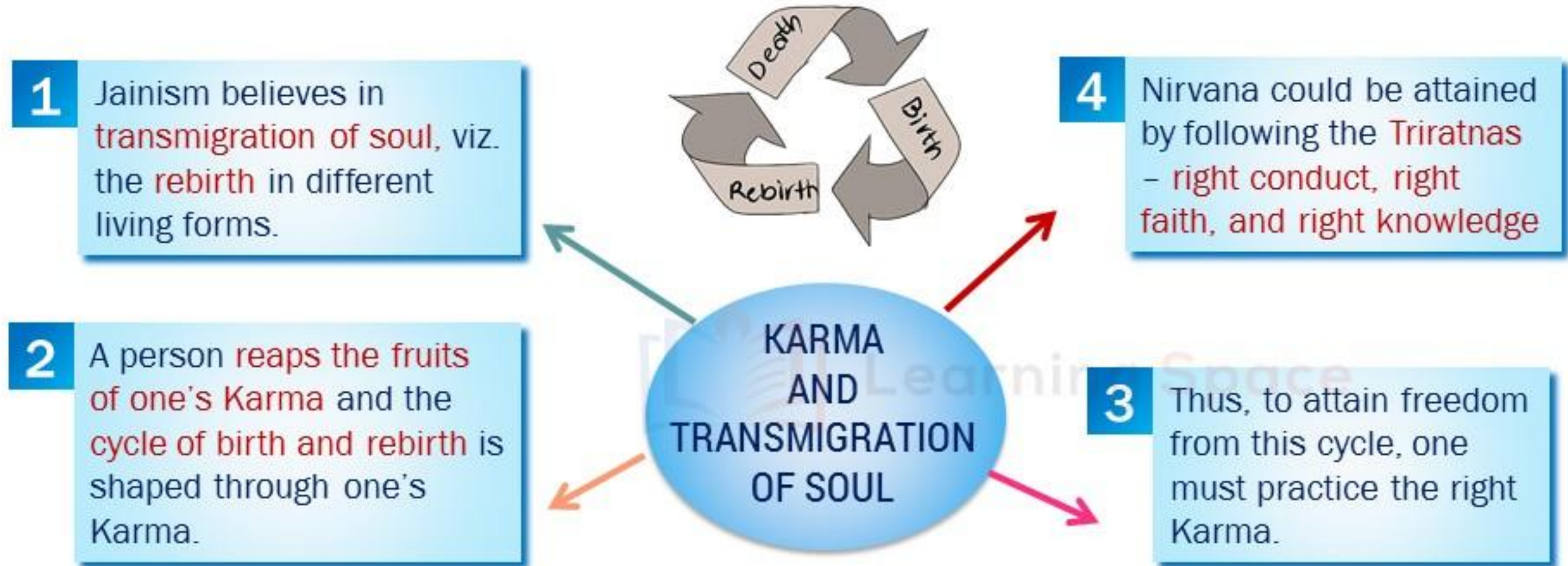
Further, they cover their mouth with a white cloth and use a broom (of fine thread called **Ogho**) to sweep where they sit, less they kill any insect.

Emphasis on the practice of Ahimsa is one of the important aspects of Jainism which distinguishes it from other religions.



AHIMSA

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHIES OF JAINISM



TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHIES OF JAINISM

SAMYAK DARSANA



TRIRATNAS
OF
JAINISM

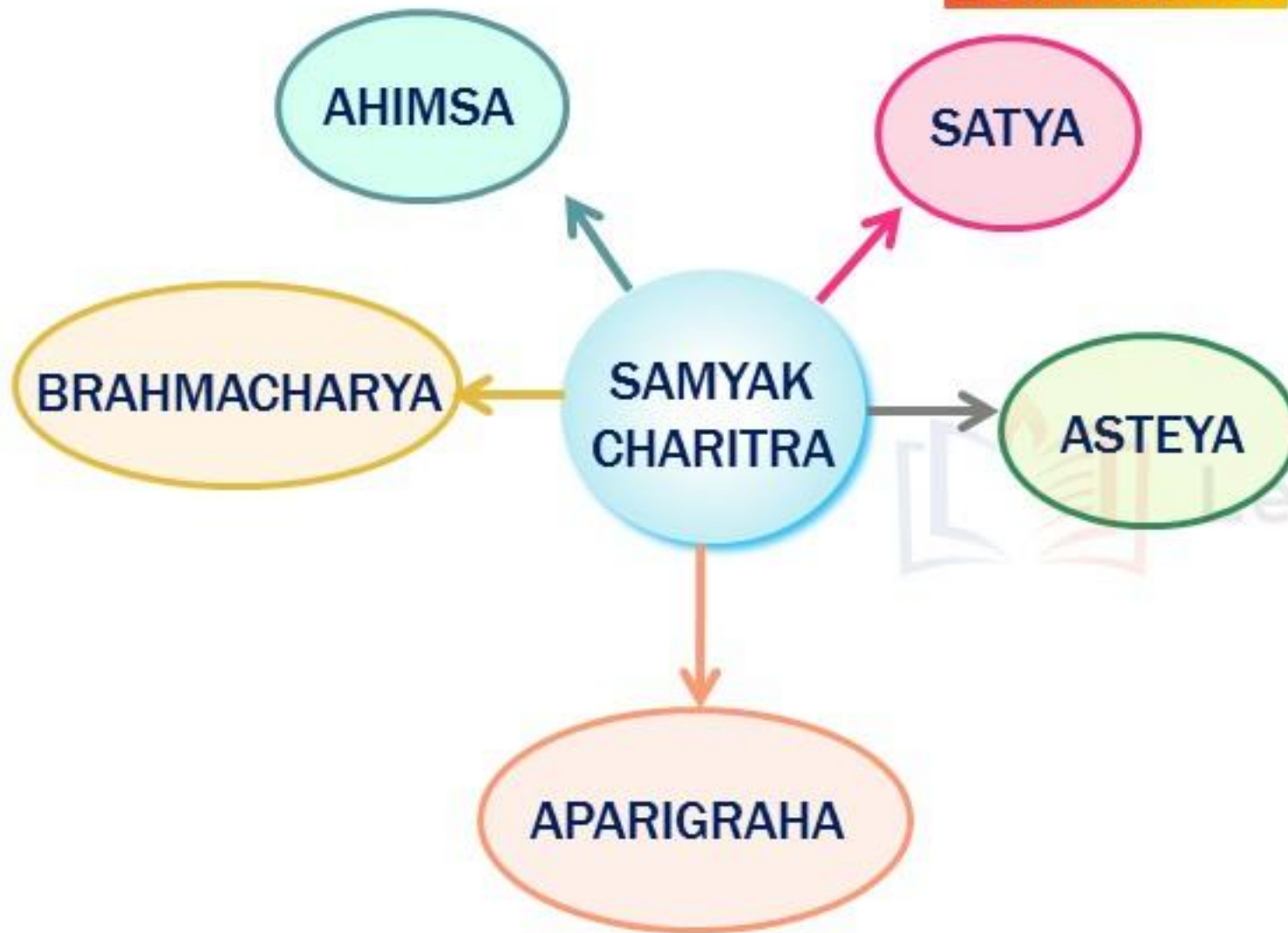
SAMYAK JNANA

SAMYAK CHARITRA

The three jewels, Samyak Charitra (right conduct), Samyak Darshana (right faith), and Samyak Jnana (right knowledge) are the core values to be adopted for attaining salvation.

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHIES OF JAINISM

TRIRATNAS



1 SAMYAK CHARITRA

- 1 This refers to right conduct which in turn includes **five vows** (Panch-Mahavrata).
- 2 These are Ahimsa (non injury/non-violence), Satya (not lying/telling truth), Asteya (non stealing), Aparigraha (non possession/non attachment), and Brahmacharya (celibacy).

JAINISM

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHIES OF JAINISM

TRIRATNAS

2

SAMYAK DARSHANA

WHAT ARE THOSE TATTVAS?

- Tattva connotes "Reality, Truth" in Jain philosophy, and is the framework for salvation.
- According to Digambara Jains, there are seven tattvas, while Śvētāmbaras believe in nine tattvas.

- Right faith or Samyak Darshan implies to understand the true nature of substance.
- To do this **one must have faith in the teachings of the Tirthankaras** which enables a person to distinguish between the right and wrong Karma.
- As per this philosophy, a person ought to believe in **Tattvas of Jain philosophy**.

JAINISM

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHIES OF JAINISM

TRIRATNAS

2

SAMYAK DARSHANA

TATTVAS OF JAIN PHILOSOPHY

Jiva	Matters which possess soul
Ajiva	Matters which do not possess soul
Asrava	Karmic influx (both evil and auspicious) into the soul
Bandha	Bondage of Karma and the soul
Samvara	Stoppage of karmic influx into the soul
Nirjara	Separation/dissociation of karmic matter from the soul
Moksha	Liberation due to separation of karmic matter from the soul.
Punya	Good Karma
Papa	Bad Karma

Found in the tattva theory of Swetambara, but not of Digambaras

JAINISM

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHIES OF JAINISM

TRIRATNAS

3

SAMYAK JNANA

As per this philosophy the right knowledge is of five kinds. These are:

- 1 Mati** (sensory knowledge): obtained through normal faculties
- 2 Srutu** (acquired knowledge) : which is verbal or non-verbal acquired words through scriptures.
- 3 Avadhi** (distant knowledge) : of remote things or clairvoyance acquired through higher faculties.
- 4 Manah prayaya** (para-normal knowledge) : or knowledge acquired psychically or telepathically.
- 5 Keval** (absolute knowledge): or perfect knowledge which is not subject to perspectives or relative standpoints.

TEACHINGS & PHILOSOPHIES OF JAINISM

DRAVYA (SUBSTANCE)

- 1 The dravya in Jainism are **fundamental entities**, called **astikaya** (literally, "collection that exists").
- 2 They are **believed to be eternal**, and the basic building blocks that constitute and explain all existence, whether perceived or not.

- 3 According to the Svetambara tradition of Jainism, there are five eternal substances in existence:
 - **Soul** (jiva),
 - **Matter** (pudgala),
 - **Space** (akasha),
 - **motion** (Dharma) and
 - **rest** (Adharma).
- 4 To this list of five, the Digambara Jain tradition adds **"Time" (kala)** as the sixth eternal substance

JAINISM

The concepts of **Syadvada** or 'conditional view points' and **Nayavada** or 'partial viewpoints' further arose from Anekantavada.

The doctrine of Anekantavada is applied by Jains in religion, philosophy, and all fields of life.

Thus, it encourages free thinking and helps in reconciliation of different perspectives.

Thus, truth as we perceive may not be taken as absolute, rather it is even relative.

Also known as the philosophy of non-absolutism or of relative pluralism, Anekantavada is among the core and distinguishing philosophies of Jainism.

As per this philosophy, "although the truth is one, but owing to different perspectives, different people perceive the same truth differently". Thus, truth can be approached in different ways.

At the same time it also forewarns us not to be too dogmatic or a stickler to one's own viewpoint as truth is not absolute.

Thus, it promotes tolerance of views and reconciles with the philosophy of non-violence.

ANEKANTAVADA

OTHER SALIENT ASPECTS OF JAIN PHILOSOPHY

VIEWS ON GOD

- Jainism recognized the existence of the gods but placed them lower than the jina.

OTHER IMPORTANT VIEWS

- Jainism was opposed to ritualism, animal sacrifices, infallibility of the Vedas, and Brahmanical superiority.
- It laid special emphasis on renunciation, austerity, and asceticism.

VIEWS ON VARNA SYSTEM

- It did not condemn the varna system, as Buddhism did.
- According to Mahavira, a person is born in a high or in a lower varna in consequence of the sins or the virtues acquired by him in the previous birth.
- Mahavira looks for human values even in a chandala.
- In his opinion, through pure and meritorious life members of the lower castes can attain liberation.
- Jainism mainly aims at the attainments of freedom from worldly bonds and no ritual is required for acquiring such liberation.

OTHER SALIENT ASPECTS OF JAIN PHILOSOPHY



ASCETICISM

- ✓ Of all the major Indian religions, Jainism has had the **strongest austerity-driven ascetic tradition**, and it is an essential part of a mendicant's spiritual pursuits.
- ✓ Ascetic life may include **nakedness** symbolizing non-possession of even clothes, **fasting**, body mortification, penance, and other austerities.
- ✓ This is done in order to **burn away past karma and stop producing new karma**, both of which are believed in Jainism to be essential for reaching moksha.

OTHER SALIENT ASPECTS OF JAIN PHILOSOPHY



FOOD & FASTING

- ✓ The practice of non-violence towards all living beings has led to Jain culture being **vegetarian**.
- ✓ Jain monks and nuns **do not eat root vegetables** such as **potatoes, onions and garlic** because tiny organisms are injured when the plant is pulled up, and because a bulb or tuber's ability to sprout is seen as characteristic of a higher living being.
- ✓ Jains fast on different occasions throughout the year, particularly during festivals. This practice is called **upavasa, tapasya or vrata**.
- ✓ The fasting practice is believed to remove karma from one's soul and allow one to gain merit (punya).

OTHER SALIENT ASPECTS OF JAIN PHILOSOPHY



MEDITATION

- ✓ Jainism considers meditation (dhyana) a necessary practice, but its goals are very different from those in Buddhism and Hinduism.
- ✓ In Jainism, **meditation is concerned more with stopping karmic attachments and activity**, not as a means to attain transformational insights or self-realization as in other Indian religions.

OTHER SALIENT ASPECTS OF JAIN PHILOSOPHY



SALLEKHANA

- ✓ The Sallekhana (or Santhara) vow is a "religious death" ritual vow observed at the end of life, historically by Jain monks and nuns, but rare in the modern age.
- ✓ In this vow, there is voluntary and gradual reduction of food and liquid intake to end one's life by choice and with dispassion.
- ✓ In Jainism this is believed to reduce negative karma that affects a soul's future rebirths.

OTHER SALIENT ASPECTS OF JAIN PHILOSOPHY



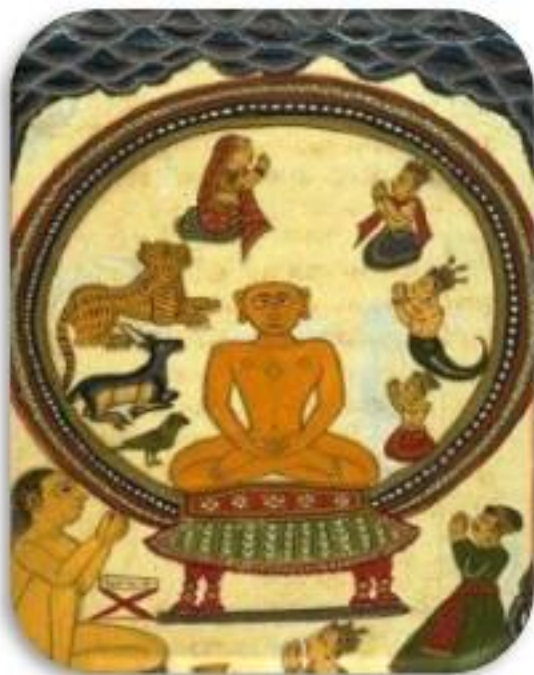
Praying at the feet of a statue of Bahubali

RITUALS & WORSHIP

- ✓ There are many rituals in Jainism's various sects.
- ✓ The **ultimate ritual is sallekhana**, a religious death through ascetic abandonment of food and drinks.
- ✓ A Jina as deva is not an avatar (incarnation) in Jainism, but the highest state of omniscience that an ascetic tirthankara has achieved.
- ✓ Out of the 24 Tirthankaras, Jain devotional worship is predominantly addressed to four: **Mahavira, Parshvanatha, Neminatha and Rishabhanatha**

JAINISM

JAIN SCRIPTURES



- 1 The teachings of Mahavira and other Tirthankars are contained in the Jain scriptures called 'Agamas'.

- 2 These Agamas were written in Prakrit.
- 3 These scriptures were not originally in written form or documented, as possessions and attachments were not permitted in the Jain philosophy.
- 4 As such, these scriptures were passed on by oral traditions for many centuries before being documented.
- 5 It is believed that after the great famine in 350 BCE, many of the Agamas were lost.

JAINISM

JAIN SCRIPTURES



- 6 Subsequently, they were recompiled and documented.
- 7 But it is also believed by Digambaras that these recompiled Agamas were not the authentic teachings of Lord Mahavira.
- 8 However, Shwetambaras believe the Agamas to be the teachings of Mahavira himself.

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